

THE BUYER AND THE SELLER

Written by

Burt Burlington
Noa J. Mouritzen-Ward

bartvdsteeg@hotmail.nl
+31616058825

INT. BAR - DAY

SELLER (35, beige suit) sits in one of the booths by his lonesome.

Behind the bar is BARKEEPER (40s) cleaning glasses and facing the labels of the hard liquor outwards.

Instead of a beer, Seller drinks coffee while reading the PAPER, fitting with his serious demeanour.

The front page headline reads:

*"Berliner Schulbrand: 9 Kinder
starben, 14 verletzt. „Wir wussten
zu spät von dem Feuer.“*

*("Berlin school fire: 9 children
died, 14 injured. "We knew about
the fire too late.")*

Seller shakes head, puts paper beside coffee.
Looks at watch. 15:04.

FRUSTRATED, he straightens his tie.

KNOCKING, front door.

Seller gets up.

Barkeeper looks over at the front door, then to Seller.

SELLER
Ten minutes, Johann.

Barkeeper SNIFFS, crosses arms, speaks with a German accent.

BARKEEPER
I don't like you doing business in
here. It gets all the wrong people.-

SELLER
-Oh, I'm terribly sorry, Johann,
evidently business is booming and
I'm at risk of ruining that.

Johan quickly scans the empty bar.

SELLER (CONT'D)
Well, if you'd rather not be a
proprietor of a pretty percentage
of the profits then I'll find an
establishment that would.

KNOCKING.

Barkeeper looks at front door, Seller is not phased.

Frustrated, he throws the rag hanging over his shoulder, on to the bar counter.

SELLER (CONT'D)
10 minutes, Johann, that's all I
ask.

Seller waits for Barkeeper to leave through the back door to open the front door, to:

BUYER (30, cheap suit, unshaven).

WIDE SHOT: OUTSIDE BAR

SELLER (CONT'D)
3 O'clock appointment?

BUYER
(calm)
Yeah.

SELLER
Come in.

BACK IN BAR:

Seller walks back to the booth, healthy pace.
Buyer takes his time, looks around.

SELLER (CONT'D)
You're 5 minutes late.
Prices have increased by 5%.

Buyer shrugs.

BUYER
(small chuckle)
I didn't expect you to be British.

SELLER
Pardon?

BUYER
I didn't expect you to be British.
I expected Russian, or Armenian or
some shit.

SELLER
Small talk is unnecessary.

BUYER
Oh, it's not meant as sm-

SELLER (CONT'D)

We don't have to know each other,
If you feel the need to address me
as anything, you may address me as
"the Seller" or simply as "Seller".
Do you ask the cashier at your
local grocery store for their name?

Buyer, silent.

BUYER

Well, they have name tags.

Seller unamused.

SELLER

(gestures to chair)

Sit.

Buyer sits, SQUEAKING of RUBBER COUCH.

Seller sits down.

Buyer looks at the newspaper - stares at it, demeanour more
serious, he needs a cigarette, takes out of breast pocket.

Seller puts the paper and coffee aside.
He bends down underneath the table to grab something.

Buyer takes deep breath and LIGHTS up CIGARETTE.

Seller comes back up.

SELLER (CONT'D)

(stern)

You put that fucking fag out right
now or we're done here.

Buyer looks at him for a second, taking a DRAG.

Seller staring daggers.

SELLER (CONT'D)

Alright, we're done.

BUYER

(hands up in innocence)

Okay, sorry, Jesus, I'm sorry.

Buyer takes cigarette out of his mouth and puts it out into a
candle.

Puts the packet back into his breast pocket.

SELLER

We're not fucking mates out for a
fag and few pints, understand?
We're here for business, I expect
you to behave accordingly.

BUYER

Yes. Sorry.

Seller just stares at him.

SMASH CUT:

Before we know it, a cloth ROLLS OUT over the newspaper and
onto the table, containing various PISTOLS, all nametagged.

SELLER

Alright, got the standard selection
here.

Pistols, revolvers, semi-
automatics, single-action.

(picks up pistol, uncocks
it, takes out magazine
etc.)

Got an Italian Berretta 92 here,
nice compact gun. Normally I oppose
anybody buying machinery from
Italy, but even the United States
military agrees with me that this
right here's a lovely little piece
of equipment.

Buyer nods along, but clear he is out of his depth.

SELLER (CONT'D)

All gun barrels are filed and all
firearms can only be traced back to
a petite Armenian shop that's been
out of business since 2005.

Seller chuckles, winks.

Buyer doesn't follow.

SELLER (CONT'D)

Meaning, impossible to trace
anything back to either you nor I.

BUYER

Ah.

SELLER

So, what are you looking for?

BUYER
Uhm. Something that can shoot.
Maybe this one?

Buyer reaches for the heavy revolver.

Seller quickly puts hand on Buyer's hand on gun.

SELLER
Don't touch anything until I say
so.

BUYER
Oh, I'm sorry, I.-

SELLER
You don't know how this works, do
you? Or, rather, are you just a
blithering idiot?

Buyer puts his hands on his lap and just looks at the Seller
insulting him.

SELLER (CONT'D)
I'll repeat myself. Do you not know
how this works? Or, are you quite
simply, just a complete and total
idiot?-

BUYER
(frustrated)
-I'm an idiot okay, I'm just an
idiot.

SELLER
(starts packing up)
I don't do business with idiots.

Buyer puts hand on Seller's arm as he is about to pack.

BUYER
(desperation)
No, please. I'm sorry, alright? I'm
sorry. I just... Please... I just
really need a gun.

Seller picks up buyer's hand and removes it from him.

SELLER
What do you plan on doing with the
gun I sell you?

BUYER
You normally ask your clients what
they do with the guns they
purchase?

SELLER
You're not like any of my normal
clients, you're an idiot.

BUYER
(reaching for gun)
Fuck you, just sell me a gun.

CLICK.

Seller points cocked pistol towards Buyer.

SELLER
Tss, tss, tss.
What did I tell you about touching
my guns...

The Buyer, presses his own temple against the Seller's loaded
pistol.

Seller narrows eyes.

SELLER (CONT'D)
You got a death wish, idiot?

Buyer is unphased.

SELLER (CONT'D)
Is this what this is all about?
(beat, disgusted)
With my guns?

BUYER
Not your business what I do with
the gun.

Seller pulls gun away from Buyer's head.

SELLER
Piss off.

Seller waves the Buyer off with the gun.

Buyer stands up, leans on table.

BUYER
I'm not leaving without a gun.

SELLER
I... don't... sell... to... idiots.

Buyer just stares the Seller down.

SLAMS WALLET filled with cash on the table.

BUYER
Well, an idiot's money is still the same as everybody else's.

SELLER
I don't do business with idiots. I have principles.

BUYER
(laugh, gobsmacked)
Principles? You sell guns! How many innocent people have died because of you?

SELLER
(slams fist on table)
For Christ's sake, compose yourself!

KNOCKING. It's the Barkeeper.

BARKEEPER (O.S.)
(behind door, frustrated)
Ten minutes are over!

SELLER
(angry)
In a minute!

Seller looks back at Buyer. Composes himself.

BUYER
(cool))
I am not leaving here without a gun. Either you take my money or you shoot me dead.

SELLER
You'd like that, wouldn't you?

BUYER
Yes. Yes I would.

SELLER
Just have some decency and jump in front of the S-Bahn like all the other suicidal people in this city.

BUYER

And traumatise some train
conductor, and the poor soul who
has to scrape me off the tracks?

Seller and Buyer hold each other's gaze.

Seller breaks it, starts packing up.

SELLER

I'm not selling you the gun.

Buyer watches him for a moment.

BUYER

Do you want to know why I want to
kill myself?

Seller freezes mid-packing.

Buyer grabs the newspaper and slams it on the table, points
at article:

*"Berliner Schulbrand: 9 Kinder
starben, 14 verletzt. „Wir wussten
zu spät von dem Feuer.“*

BUYER (CONT'D)

A year ago, the company I worked
for was in charge of renovating a
school.

(points at article)

This school.

I supervised the project and wanted
to save the company some money, so
instead of getting reliant 50 Euro
smoke detectors, I chose the 35
Euro ones.

(beat)

They didn't trigger in time.

(beat)

I saved the company 330 Euros that
day...

Buyer drops his head. First time the Seller doesn't know what
to say.

Buyer snuffles, wipes his nose, then lifts his head. He pulls
out all the cash in his cash-filled wallet and plops it on
the table. About 2000 Euros.

BUYER (CONT'D)
That's about two thousand Euros.
I'm sure it is enough.

He slips the HEAVY REVOLVER out of the assortment of guns,
gets up and walks off.

Seller sits motionless in his seat.

Buyer reaches for the doorknob of the front door.

SELLER (O.S.)
Wenton?

Buyer stops.

SELLER (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Joseph Wenton?

WENTON
(doesn't look back,
furious)
Yes?

Seller looks at Joseph's driver's license from his wallet.

SELLER
Please, sit down with me, Joseph.

Joseph just clenches his fist, PISTOL SHAKING.

SELLER (CONT'D)
One act of negligence does not make
you a heinous man.

Joseph EXHALES, almost as if flames can come out.

SELLER (CONT'D)
You cannot trade your life for
theirs. What's done is done.

Joseph, grabs the door knob.

SELLER (CONT'D)
There are no bullets in there,
Joseph.

It doesn't take long, until Wenton starts WEEPING.

SELLER (CONT'D)
Sit down, Joseph.

Wenton turns around and puts the HEAVY PISTOL on the table and sits down, hides his crying eyes with his arms while leaning on the table.

Barkeeper ENTERS through back door.

BARKEEPER

Okay, no more! I don't want you to do business in my-

SELLER

(raises two fingers)

-Two pints, Johann.

Barkeeper is a bit stumped.

Wenton dries his tears on his sleeves.

Seller holds up a handful of 100 Euro bills.

Barkeeper pours two pints and brings them to the table.

Seller hands him the handful of 100s.

SELLER (CONT'D)

Here you go, Johann, keep the change, too.

Barkeeper shocked, counts the bills.

WENTON

(snotty nose)

Asshole, that's my money.

Seller just CHUCKLES.

Barkeeper holds the money and looks at Wenton.

WENTON (CONT'D)

-It's fine. Keep it.

Seller just smiles at Johann.

BARKEEPER

(German-ness comes out)

Danke! Thank you very much.

Barkeeper walks off happily.

Seller takes a sip of his beer.

He reaches into Buyer's breast pocket, pulls out the cigarettes, lights it on the candle flame, and puts it in his mouth.

He takes a long inhale.

SELLER
You can call me Arthur.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END